Week 8 Teacher Guide — The Church's Tests: Obeying the Gospel and the Table

The Obedience of Faith, Week 8 of 12. Unit III (Testing). Companion to `Week08-TheChurchsTests.pptx` *(7 slides, 23 click-stops). Scripture from the NET Bible.*

Aim: Answer the course's sharpest question — what specific obedience-of-faith tests does the New Covenant set for the church?

What this week must accomplish (and nothing more): the class leaves able to name the four categories of the church's tests — *entry, recurring, continuous, providential* (with the final judgment as providential's endpoint) — and holding one reframe that will change how they take communion: *the Lord's Supper is a scheduled, commanded self-test, not merely a ritual to perform.* This is the payoff week of Unit III; Week 7 established that every covenant tests faith, and this week says: here are ours, by name. If the class can locate the four categories and understands the table as a weekly examination, the week succeeded.

Keep the guardrail lit. This is the second week of a unit called "Testing," and the works-righteousness reflex is still live — especially now that we're naming *specific commanded acts* (confession, baptism, self-examination). Reinforce the Week 4/7 frame at least twice: **these tests come to the already-rescued; they prove and reveal a faith saved by grace, they do not purchase standing.** The bridge logic on slide 2 actually helps here — a command is where trust *becomes action*, and it's addressed to a person God is already saving. Say it plainly whenever a face tightens.

Where this sits in the arc: Week 7 surveyed the covenant tests from Eden to Christ and ended on "salvation to all who obey him" (Heb 5:9). This week takes that "obey him" and asks: concretely, what does the New Covenant ask? Week 9 then narrows further to the living sacrifice (Rom 12) — the reading assignment already points there.

Segment 1 — The Gospel Is Something Obeyed (0:00–10:00 · Slide 2)

The three bridge texts (first click). The New Testament routinely speaks of the gospel not merely as *believed* but as *obeyed*: "those who do not obey the gospel" (2 Thess 1:8), "disobedient to the gospel of God" (1 Pet 4:17), and conversion itself described as having "obeyed from the heart that pattern of teaching" (Rom 6:17). This is ordinary apostolic language, and it should reframe how the class hears "gospel" — not just a message to assent to, but a summons to answer.

The logic (second click). A gospel can be *obeyed* only because it *contains commands*. And a command is, by its nature, a test — the point where trust in the word has to become action, where invisible faith becomes a visible event (Unit III's whole theme). This is precisely how a gospel of pure grace still carries real tests without becoming works-salvation: the command comes *to the one being rescued*, calling forth the response of a faith God is already giving.

2 Corinthians 2:9 (third click) — the single sharpest text in the course for this thesis. Paul says he *writes his letters in order to test obedience*: "For this reason also I wrote you: to test you to see if you are obedient in everything." Apostolic instruction is *by design* a test. When the class reads a New Testament command, they are reading a test God set for the church.

The Romans loop (fourth click). This closes the frame from Week 1: Paul's entire apostleship exists "to bring about the *obedience of faith*" (Rom 1:5, 16:26) — the course's title phrase, the letter's opening and closing bookend. Then name the four categories the lecture will walk: **entry, recurring, continuous, providential.** Preview only; each gets its own segment.

Transition: "Start at the door — the entry test."

Segment 2 — The Entry Test: Obeying the Gospel (10:00–22:00 · Slide 3)

The threshold commands (first click): the gospel's commands at the point of entry — confess ("if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord… you will be saved," Rom 10:9), repent ("God now commands all people everywhere to repent," Acts 17:30 — note *commands*, and *all people everywhere*, so the test is universal in scope), and be baptized ("Repent, and each one of you be baptized," Acts 2:38). Frame these carefully: they are not *additions to* faith, as if faith needed topping up. They are what believing faith *does* when it meets the gospel's call — the shape trust takes at the threshold. And keep grace first: the command is addressed to someone being rescued, not someone earning rescue.

Luke 7:29–30 (second click) — **the jewel of the week, and worth slowing down for.** Luke pauses his narrative to tell us what response to a commanded washing *revealed*: "the Pharisees and the experts in religious law rejected God's purpose for themselves, because they had not been baptized by John." Read that carefully — their refusal of a modest water rite *was* the recorded verdict on their entire posture toward God's purpose. Meanwhile the common people "acknowledged God's justice" *by being baptized* (7:29). This is exactly the shape of Eden's tree and Abraham's mountain: a concrete, seemingly small act whose acceptance or refusal discloses everything about a heart's relationship to God's word. The water didn't create the posture; it *exposed* it.

Colossians 2:11–12 (third click): Paul plants baptism precisely where the old covenant's entry-marker stood — "in him you were also circumcised… having been buried with him in baptism… raised with him through faith." The New

Covenant has an entry-marker just as the Abrahamic covenant did (Week 7). **A pastoral caution:** do not let this segment become a debate over baptism's mode or precise mechanics — that will hijack the hour and divide a mixed class. The *point* is structural: entry into covenant has always involved a commanded, revealing act, and the church's is baptism "through faith." Teach the pattern; leave the intramural mechanics for another setting.

Romans 6:17 (fourth click): conversion itself is described as a *test passed* — "you obeyed from the heart that pattern of teaching." Belief that became obedient action. That is what walking through the door looks like.

Transition: "Entry happens once. But the covenant also schedules a *recurring* test."

Segment 3 — The Recurring Test: The Table (22:00–32:00 · Slide 4)

1 Corinthians 11:28 (first click). The Mosaic covenant scheduled its tests — weekly Sabbath, annual feasts, daily manna. The New Covenant schedules one too, and the examination is *commanded outright*: "A person should examine himself first, and in this way let him eat the bread and drink of the cup." This reframes communion for most of the class — from a ritual to *perform* into a test to *pass*, on a recurring schedule.

The verb (second click): *dokimazetō* — the assayer's word from Week 5's verification toolkit, now turned *inward.* The Lord's Supper is the *only* ordinance in the New Testament with a standing, repeated, commanded self-test attached, and it carries real consequences for careless approach (11:27–30 — "weak and sick… some have died"). **Handle 11:27–30 soberly, not to terrify.** The point is not "communion is dangerous, be scared"; it's that God takes the covenant meal seriously enough to attach an examination — and the self-examination is the *mercy* that heads off the judgment. The exam is the guardrail, not the threat.

The assembly (third click, Heb 10:24–25): "not abandoning our own meetings, as some are in the habit of doing." Frame this pastorally: chronic absence from the assembly is treated as a *symptom*, not a scheduling problem — withdrawal usually reveals something upstream in the heart. This is "come or something's wrong," diagnostically, rather than "come or else," punitively.

Forgiveness (fourth click, Matt 6:14–15): Jesus makes forgiveness explicitly *conditional* — "if you forgive… your Father will also forgive you; but if you do not forgive… neither will your Father forgive you." Conditional means diagnostic: an unforgiving heart carried to the table is a warning light on the dashboard. Land the segment: every week the covenant meal asks the covenant question — *is the faith you professed at the door still real at the table?*

Transition: "Beyond the scheduled tests, two more kinds run constantly — and there's a final one."

Segment 4 — The Continuous, the Providential, the Final (32:00–45:00 · Slide 5)

Three columns build on clicks; take about three minutes each, then the summary.

CONTINUOUS — 1 John's "by this we know" (first click). One New Testament book is structured entirely as a series of tests — older writers called 1 John "the tests of life." Its refrain is *by this we know*: the **moral** test ("by this we know we have come to know God: if we keep his commandments," 2:3), the **relational** test ("by this we know we have crossed from death to life: because we love our fellow Christians," 3:14), and the **doctrinal** test ("test the spirits… confession of Christ come in the flesh," 4:1–3). These aren't tests you sit once; they're the standing evidences that faith is alive — and note, this is where *assurance* grows (tie back to Week 4's Spirit-witness: assurance rests on God's work confirmed by these fruits, not on a performance scorecard).

PROVIDENTIAL — trials and wealth (second click). The tests God *sends* rather than *commands*. Suffering proves genuineness — "the testing of your faith produces endurance… that the proven character of your faith, more valuable than gold, may bring praise and glory" (James 1:2–3, 12; 1 Pet 1:6–7) — the refining fire from Week 7. And the startling one: **money is the church's manna.** Paul calls a giving opportunity a test outright — "I am testing the genuineness of your love" (2 Cor 8:8) — the daily, ongoing proof of which master is actually served (Matt 6:24). The wallet is where invisible devotion becomes visible fastest.

FINAL — the last exam (third click). Self-examine *now* so the last exam holds no surprises: "examine yourselves to see whether you are in the faith" (2 Cor 13:5). And the criterion at the end is not profession but enacted faith: "Not everyone who says 'Lord, Lord' will enter the kingdom… but the one who *does the will* of my Father" (Matt 7:21), sealed by the two builders (7:24–27) — same sermon *heard* by both, but the storm reveals who *built* on doing versus hearing-only.

The summary (fourth click): 1 John as the tests-of-life book; the final court weighs deeds that *flow from* faith, not profession alone. **Keep grace close here or the slide can land as terror** — this judges the *reality* of faith, it does not swap grace for merit. Ephesians 2:10: we are "created in Christ Jesus *for* good works" — the works are the evidence and fruit of salvation, never its purchase (Week 4's whole point). The one who does the Father's will does it *because* he's been saved, not in order to be.

Segments 5–6 — Discussion and Close (45:00–57:00 · Slides 6–7)

Q1 — "Of the four, which does our congregation talk about least? Why that one?" A gentle mirror, not a complaint session. Many churches over-emphasize *entry* (get baptized, get saved) and under-emphasize the *con-*

tinuous and *providential* (daily proving, suffering, generosity) — or the reverse. Whatever the class names, turn it constructive: "What would it look like to recover attention to that one?" Don't let it become criticism of leadership or other members.

Q2 — "What does weekly self-examination at the table actually involve?" The practical heart of the week. Guide toward what 1 Corinthians 11 (in context) actually examines *for*: unconfessed sin, division with a brother (that was the literal Corinthian problem — 11:18–21), an unforgiving heart (Matt 6), treating the holy casually. **Steer away from the morbid version** — "am I good enough to take this?" is the very scoreboard Week 4 removed, and it will send tender consciences into despair. The right question is not "am I worthy?" (no one is; that's why there's a table) but "am I coming in faith and love, or in pretense and grudge?" Model it briefly out loud so they hear the difference.

The close (slide 7, ~2 min). Next week: The Altar Today — the living sacrifice. Reading: Romans 12:1–2 (body *and* mind on the altar) and Malachi 1:6–14 (the blemished offerings — "would you hand it to your governor?"), both flagged. Preview Week 9. Carry sentence — the four categories in one line: *the church's faith is tested at the door, at the table, in the life, and through the fire.* Close on 2 Corinthians 13:5 as an *invitation* to self-examine, framed by grace rather than fear. Dismiss on time.

Answers to Questions You May Get

"Aren't confession, repentance, and baptism 'works'? Doesn't this contradict Week 4's grace?" No — and this is the week's central clarification, so welcome the question. A work, in the sense Paul condemns, is something you do *to earn or merit* standing before God (Rom 4:4–5; Eph 2:8–9). These commands are the *response of faith to grace already offered* — the way a drowning man "works" by grabbing the rope isn't earning his rescue; it's receiving it. Baptism is explicitly tied to *faith* ("through faith," Col 2:12) and to what *God* does in it (burial and resurrection *with Christ*), not to human achievement. The order is always grace first: God commands the already-rescued (Israel redeemed, *then* Sinai). Obedience is faith's shape, not its price (Week 4).

"Does 1 Corinthians 11 mean I shouldn't take communion if I've sinned that week?" The opposite, rightly understood. The command is to *examine* — which means confess and set things right — *and then eat* ("in this way let him eat," 11:28). It's not "stay away if you're a sinner"; everyone at the table is a sinner, which is the whole point of the table. It's "don't come *carelessly, in unrepentant sin or active division*, treating the holy as common." The unworthy *manner* (11:27) is the problem, not the unworthy *person.* Examine, repent, and come — the meal is for sinners who are turning, not for the already-perfect.

"Matthew 7:21 says not everyone who says 'Lord, Lord' is saved —

how can I have assurance?" Look at *who* Jesus is describing: people who called him Lord while working "lawlessness" (7:23) — profession with no corresponding life, "Lord, Lord" that never became "the will of my Father." The verse is a warning against *empty profession*, not against assurance for genuine faith. Assurance comes exactly where 1 John locates it (this week's continuous tests): do I obey, do I love, do I hold the truth — not perfectly, but *really*? Those fruits, plus the Spirit's witness (Rom 8:16, Week 4), are how a true believer knows. The person who *worries* about this is usually not the person Jesus is warning about; the lawless were serenely confident.

"Which is more important — entry (baptism) or the continuous life?" A false choice; Scripture insists on both, and neglecting either is dangerous. Entry without the continuing life is the seed on rocky ground — a start with no root (Matt 13:20–21). The continuing life without a real entry is trying to bear fruit without being grafted in. The four categories aren't ranked; they're the *whole shape* of a tested faith across a lifetime — born at the door, fed at the table, proven in the living, refined through the fire.

"Isn't calling giving a 'test' manipulative — like a preacher pressuring for money?" Understandable worry, and the text guards against it. Paul explicitly says "I am *not* saying this as a command" (2 Cor 8:8) — he refuses to coerce; he *invites*, and names the giving as an *opportunity* for love to prove itself genuine. The test isn't manipulation *toward* the church's coffers; it's a mirror showing the giver's own heart — is my professed love real enough to cost me something (Week 2's whole thesis: love becomes visible when it pays)? Money reveals allegiance faster than words because "where your treasure is, there your heart will be also" (Matt 6:21). The test is for the giver's clarity, not the fundraiser's leverage.

Prep Checklist

- ☐ Read Luke 7:24–35 whole — the Pharisees-rejected-baptism verdict needs its context to land
- ☐ Read 1 Corinthians 11:17–34 entire — the *division at Corinth* is what "examine yourselves" originally addressed
- ☐ Read 1 John looking for the "by this we know" refrains (2:3; 3:14, 19, 24; 4:13; 5:2) — there are more than three
- ☐ Reread Ephesians 2:8–10 so you can answer the "isn't this works?" question crisply
- ☐ Decide, in advance, how you'll model healthy (not morbid) table self-examination out loud
- ☐ Rehearse the four-category structure so the class can repeat it — it's the week's retention goal
- ☐ Print/post next week's reading with both flags (body-and-mind, the governor test)

If You Run Long

Cut in this order: compress the three bridge texts on slide 2 to two (keep 2 Thess 1:8 and Rom 6:17); trim the Colossians 2 discussion on slide 3 (name it, don't unpack — and definitely don't open the mode debate); shorten the providential column's wealth material on slide 5 to the 2 Cor 8:8 quote alone. **Never cut:** Luke 7:29–30 (the jewel), the *dokimazetō* self-examination on slide 4, the grace-anchor on slide 5's summary, or the four-category naming. If discussion must shrink, keep Q2 — the practical "what am I examining for?" question is what changes how people take communion next Sunday, which is the week's most tangible fruit.